SCENE 005 — HATTIE & THE INN

Trigger: Scene 004 resolution — all three outcome paths lead here **Time:** Morning — sun up, town moving **Location:** Hattie's Inn, main road, Wroughtwood **Incoming Flags:** PRUITT_REL, TOWN_FIRST_IMPRESSION, CLOTHES_RECEIVED, FIRST_NIGHT_PAID

CONDITIONAL OPENING — Based on PRUITT_REL

[CORDIAL — Pruitt sent him] You find the inn easy enough — a two story clapboard building with a hand-painted sign above the door, white paint going gray at the edges. A porch with two chairs. A window box that still has last summer's dead flowers in it. The door is open.

You're in clean clothes. Pruitt's son's clothes — they fit close enough. The blood is gone. You almost look like a man who belongs somewhere.

[WATCHED — Arrived alone] The inn sits back from the main road slightly, like it's been there long enough to settle. A porch. Two chairs. An open door. You're aware of the eyes following you from the feed store across the road as you climb the steps. Calhoun's men. You don't look back.

You still have dried blood under your fingernails. You didn't have anywhere to clean up properly.

[HOSTILE — Released from cell] Pruitt walked you out of the cell at midday without ceremony. Pointed at the inn and said *Miss Hattie.* That was it. Half the town saw you come out of that jail. The walk across the road is the longest fifty feet you've ever covered.

You're still in the torn, bloodied clothes. The town's first image of you was a man the sheriff brought in. You can feel that image sitting on your back like something with weight.

THE INN — Interior

Inside smells like biscuits and lye soap and something underneath both of those things — old wood, old curtains, the particular smell of a building that has absorbed thirty years of other people's lives. A counter near the door with a brass bell on it. A staircase going up to the right. A narrow hall leading toward the back where kitchen sounds come from.

On the wall behind the counter — a framed needlepoint that reads *EVERY MAN EARNS HIS REST.*

You've heard something like that already today.

Before you can reach the bell she appears from the hallway — wiping her hands on an apron, moving with the unhurried authority of a woman in her own space. Sixty, maybe more. White hair pinned back, a face that has spent decades deciding what deserves a reaction and what doesn't. Eyes that are brown and very direct.

She looks at you.

Not at the torn clothes, not at what's left of the blood. At you. The distinction is immediate and specific and you feel it.

"You'll be the young man Ray Pruitt called ahead about," she says. Her voice is low and unhurried, a particular Southern sound that's been smoothed by time. *"Or you'll be someone else entirely, in which case you've had quite a morning regardless."*

She comes to the counter and sets both hands on it, studying you with the frank attention of someone who has seen enough of the world to skip the preamble.

"I'm Hattie. This is my inn."

PLAYER CHOICES — First Impression

A — "Marcus Grave. Pruitt said you might have a room."

Stat Effect: COMPOSURE maintains **Hattie Response:** She nods slowly. Something in her face moves when he says the name — brief, internal, gone before it can be read. *"Marcus Grave,"* she repeats, like she's placing it somewhere. *"I've got a room on the second floor, end of the hall. Quiet. You'll want quiet."* She reaches under the counter for a key. *"Ray's covering tonight. After that you earn it or you find somewhere else. That's not hardness — that's how this works."*

B — Introduce yourself and thank her for taking him in

Stat Effect: HUMANITY +5 **Hattie Response:** She looks at him a moment with an expression that isn't quite surprise but is close to it — like gratitude is rarer currency in Wroughtwood than it should be. *"Don't thank me yet,"* she says, but not unkindly. *"Let's see how the week goes."* She comes around the counter. *"Come on. I'll show you up."*

C — Ask if she knows what happened on the road last night

Stat Effect: CLARITY +1 — Marcus is still trying to piece it together **Hattie Response:** She goes very still. Not the stillness of ignorance — the stillness of a woman deciding how much to give away. *"I heard there was trouble on the north road,"* she says, carefully. *"That's not unusual out here. The north road has always had trouble."* She meets his eyes. *"Get cleaned up. Eat something. The answers you're looking for don't get clearer on an empty stomach."* She hands him the key. The conversation is over — for now. **Flag Set:** HATTIE_PROBED_EARLY — she knows he's asking. She'll watch how he asks going forward.

D — Say nothing. Just take the key.

Stat Effect: RAGE +5 — the morning has used him up **Hattie Response:** She slides the key across the counter without ceremony. But as Marcus picks it up her hand doesn't move away entirely. Not stopping him. Just present. *"Second floor, end of the hall,"* she says. *"Washroom's across from it. There's a change of clothes on the bed — my husband's. They'll fit close enough."* She pauses. *"You don't have to talk. But you do have to eat. Kitchen's open till noon."* **Note:** She offers the husband's clothes regardless of whether CLOTHES_RECEIVED is already set — if Marcus already has Pruitt's son's clothes she offers them for washing instead. Small detail. Real one.

THE ROOM

Second floor. End of the hall. A window that faces the main road on one side and if Marcus looks from the right angle — the far edge of town, where the land goes soft and the willows begin.

The room is small and clean. A bed with a quilt that has been washed so many times the pattern is a suggestion. A washstand with a mirror. A hook on the wall. A window with a curtain that moves in the draft.

On the bed — a folded set of clothes. Dark trousers, a work shirt, worn soft. A man's clothes. Her husband's.

Marcus cleans up. Looks at himself in the mirror.

THE MIRROR — Internal Moment

> *This is a quiet stat-check scene. No choices. Just Marcus looking at himself.*

IF HUMANITY > 70: The face looking back is his. Tired and wrong-placed and carrying more than it should — but his. Marcus Grave, twenty-five years old, still mostly intact. He looks at his hands. Still clean. Still no marks.

Somewhere out there Curtis is missing. That's the thing to hold onto. Find Curtis. Everything else follows from that.

IF HUMANITY 40–70: The face looking back is familiar but something in the eyes is different. Not wild. Not wrong. Just — present in a way eyes aren't usually present. Like something behind them is paying attention. Marcus looks away first.

IF HUMANITY < 40: He stands at the mirror longer than he means to. The face is his. But for one moment — half a second, a trick of the light through the curtain — something else looks back. He steps away from the mirror. Doesn't go back to it.

Stat Effect: HUNGER +5 — even the quiet feeds it.

HATTIE'S KITCHEN — The Real Conversation

She feeds him. No discussion about it — a plate appears at the kitchen table while he's still finding a chair. Biscuits, salt pork, black coffee. Real food. The kind that reminds a body it exists.

She moves around the kitchen while he eats. Not hovering. Working. But present.

After a while she speaks. She doesn't sit down to do it.

"You're not the first stranger to come out of that field," she says. Flat. Factual. Like she's been deciding whether to say it for the last twenty minutes. *"Won't be the last either, I expect."*

She doesn't look at him when she says it.

"This town has a long memory. Longer than most people who live in it know." She turns to refill his coffee without being asked. *"You're going to hear things while you're here. About the woods. About what comes out of them."* She sets the pot down. *"Most of what you hear will be fear dressed up as fact. Some of it won't be."*

She looks at him now. Direct and deliberate.

"You'll know the difference when it matters."

She says nothing else about it.

PLAYER CHOICES — After Breakfast

A — Ask her what she knows about the woods

Stat Effect: CLARITY +1 **Hattie Response:** She considers him. Considers how much to give. *"I know they're old,"* she says. *"Older than this town. Older than the people who built it."* She wipes down the counter. *"There's things out there that were here before us and will be here after. This town mostly tries to pretend otherwise."* A pause. *"Mostly."* **Flag Set:** HATTIE_WOODS_KNOWLEDGE_1 — first of several layers she'll reveal slowly over multiple interactions

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B — Ask about the woman in the swamp

Stat Effect: TRUST_MARIE +1 — showing interest moves the needle **Hattie Response:** The counter gets wiped again. Same spot. *"Marie,"* she says. Just the name. Then quiet for long enough that Marcus wonders if that's all she'll give. *"She's been here longer than anyone in this town will admit."* Something crosses her face — complicated, private, not for sharing. *"If you need her, she'll know before you knock."* She picks up his empty plate. *"Don't go at night. Not yet."* **Flag Set:** HATTIE_MENTIONED_MARIE — Hattie has now pointed Marcus toward Marie, same as Harlan. Two people who know things have now aimed him at the same place.

C — Ask about work — how does a man earn around here

Stat Effect: COMPOSURE +1 **Hattie Response:** Something in her relaxes slightly — a practical question from a practical man. *"I've got things need doing around this inn that I can't pay much for but I can pay something. Firewood split, gutters cleared, guest rooms turned over."* She leans against the counter. *"There's also folk in town who need odd work done but won't ask a stranger directly. You make yourself visible and useful and the work finds you."* She pauses. *"Calhoun runs the feed store. He always needs hands. I'd steer clear of him personally but that's your call."* **Flag Set:** INN_JOBS_AVAILABLE — activates inn job mechanic

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D — Thank her for the food and go upstairs

Stat Effect: HUMANITY +5 — knowing when to be still is human **Hattie Response:** She nods. *"Room's yours till morning. After that, we talk about what comes next."* As Marcus reaches the kitchen door she speaks again, not turning around. *"Marcus."* A pause. *"Whatever happened to you on that road — it doesn't have to be the whole story. You understand me?"* She goes back to her work before he can answer.

INN JOB BOARD — Activated by Choice C or Day 2+

> *Available from Day 1 if Choice C selected. Appears automatically Day 2 regardless.*

Jobs cycle daily. Each job pays a small amount and provides a stat effect or flag. Some jobs put Marcus in proximity to key NPCs.

Job	Employer	Pay	Stat Effect	Side Effect
Split firewood	Hattie	$1.50	HEALTH +5	None
Clear gutters at the feed store	Calhoun (indirect)	$2.00	COMPOSURE +5	CALHOUN_PROXIMITY — Calhoun observes Marcus
Deliver groceries for Hattie	Various	$1.00	AWARENESS +5	Marcus sees inside several homes — town geography expands
Fix fence at the church	Reverend Cade	$1.50	HUMANITY +5	CADE_MET — introduces Reverend Cade
Haul feed bags at the mill	Mill foreman	$2.50	HEALTH +5	MILL_AREA_KNOWN — Marcus learns the layout near Marie's swamp
Watch the front desk (evening)	Hattie	$1.00	AWARENESS +10	Marcus overhears guest conversations — gossip unlocked

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DAY 3 — DARNELL'S CALL

> *Regardless of what Marcus is doing on Day 3, this triggers at the inn.*

The phone at the front desk rings in the evening. Hattie answers it. Her face doesn't change but something in her posture does — a tightening, controlled and practiced.

She holds the receiver out toward Marcus without a word.

"It's for you," she says.

Marcus takes it.

"Marcus." The voice on the other end is flat and familiar. Not angry. Anger would be easier. *"You got something of mine. You know what I'm talking about."*

Darnell.

"I'm going to give you three days. Then I'm going to come get it myself."

The line goes dead.

Hattie takes the receiver back. Sets it in the cradle. Looks at Marcus.

She doesn't ask who it was.

"Whatever that is," she says quietly, *"deal with it before it comes through my door."*

Flag Set: DARNELL_CALL_RECEIVED, DARNELL_THREE_DAY_TIMER begins **Stat Effect:** RAGE +10, COMPOSURE -5

SCENE NOTES

- **Hattie's husband's clothes** — she offers them without being asked and doesn't explain the husband. He is gone. That's all that needs to be said right now. The detail matters later.
- **"You're not the first stranger to come out of that field"** is the most she'll give Marcus unprompted in this scene. She's been watching this town for decades. She knows the pattern. She's choosing to give Marcus a warning dressed as observation.
- **Two people have now pointed Marcus toward Marie** — Harlan and Hattie, from completely different positions, with completely different relationships to the truth. That convergence should register.
- **The mirror scene** is the first internal stat visualization — the player sees what HUMANITY actually means reflected back at them in plain language.
- **Hattie and Marie's private history** is never referenced directly in this scene. But the way Hattie says *Marie* — just the name, then silence, then a wiped counter — carries everything.
- **Darnell's call through the inn phone** is a violation of the one safe space Marcus has found. It means he was traceable. It means Darnell is already moving.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
INN_ESTABLISHED	All paths — Marcus has a room
HATTIE_MET	All paths
HATTIE_PROBED_EARLY	Choice C at arrival
HATTIE_WOODS_KNOWLEDGE_1	Breakfast Choice A
HATTIE_MENTIONED_MARIE	Breakfast Choice B
INN_JOBS_AVAILABLE	Breakfast Choice C or Day 2
CALHOUN_PROXIMITY	Feed store gutter job taken
CADE_MET	Church fence job taken
MILL_AREA_KNOWN	Mill job taken — eases path to Marie's swamp
DARNELL_CALL_RECEIVED	Day 3, automatic
DARNELL_THREE_DAY_TIMER	Day 3, automatic

LEADS TO

SCENE 006 — WROUGHTWOOD (Free Exploration) Marcus has a room, a name in town, and a clock ticking. The town opens up — Calhoun, Reverend Cade, the teens, the north road, the swamp's edge. Day and night cycles begin. HUNGER climbs. The moon is out there somewhere getting fuller.